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RESEARCH

Zeroes in a Zero-Sum Game: A Netnographic Analysis of Incels' Construction of Inequality in the Manosphere

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Abstract

In the Manosphere, a digital space hostile to women, men are depicted as victims of women's gains. The belief that women's advancements come at the expense of men is a product of a zero-sum worldview, which posits that one group's success comes at a cost to others. Importantly, research on zero-sum ideology tends to focus on power between rather than within groups. This focus overlooks grievances of less-advantaged members of privileged groups, such as men who do not receive full benefits of masculine privilege. In this analysis, we examine the ways incels (i.e., involuntary celibates) construct inequality in a presumed zero-sum game. Through a netnography of incels.is, we find that users cast inceldom as a disability and marginalized sexual identity, calling for an uprising to secure reparations for the denial of masculine privilege they believe they are owed (e.g., women's sexual attention). We call this process *zeroing out*, defined as the strategic adoption of systemic inequality in a way that appropriates the experiences of the underprivileged to secure the entitlements one feels owed, but denied, as a lower-status member of a privileged group. We believe our findings have implications for the way we view hierarchies of power within privileged groups.

Keywords Incels · Manosphere · Masculinities · Inequality

In the digital space of the Manosphere, men are depicted as unjust victims of women's gains. Conceptualized as a loosely connected network where hostility toward women is expressed, the Manosphere deploys "narratives of personal suffering to build affective consensus about an allegedly collective, gendered experience, namely men's [inferior] position in the social hierarchy as a result of feminism" (Ging, 2019, p. 653). In other words, the Manosphere reinforces the notion that men are systemically oppressed by women and feminism (Dickel & Evolvi, 2023; Dignam & Rohlinger, 2019; Górska et al., 2023; Ribeiro et al., 2021). The victimization narrative that pervades the Manosphere depicts a very different view of feminism than what previous men's groups have espoused. As Messner (1998) describes, men's rights activists of past decades saw themselves as allies to feminists, as both groups saw rigid gender roles as being harmful to men and women alike. Yet, over time, men's rights groups splintered into feminist and anti-feminist sects, with the latter circulating victimization narratives that mirror those that are characteristic of the Manosphere today.

In the Manosphere, (generally White, straight) men do not see themselves as being privileged in an unequal society, and to reconcile their belief that possessing privilege in an oppressive system would make them immoral oppressors, they construct themselves as victims of feminism (Carian, 2024). For example, users in the Manosphere claim that women's increased sexual agency has resulted in men's unrealized sexual entitlement to women's bodies – and has even created a widespread culture of false rape allegations (Dickel & Evolvi, 2023; Gotell & Dutton, 2016; Kettrey et al., 2024; Vallerga, 2024). These grievances are often used to justify violence against women and/or the removal of women's basic rights as a tool of retribution or subordination (Chang, 2022; Davis & Kettrey, 2024; de Roos et al., 2024; Dickel & Evolvi, 2023; Górska et al., 2023; Lockyer et al., 2025; Regehr, 2022). The idea that the gains of feminism come at the expense of men is a product of a zero-sum worldview, which posits that resources/power cannot

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be distributed to one group without detracting from another (Foster, 1965). In this analysis, we examine the ways that involuntary celibates (i.e., incels), a Manosphere group that is adept at self-deprecation and self-loathing, construct themselves as victims of inequality in a presumed gender zero-sum game.

The Zero-Sum Worldview

Zero-sum beliefs have historically been defined as a worldview in which one party's gains are accrued at another party's equivalent expense. These beliefs tend to arise in the presence of a perceived threat (e.g., when a high-status group perceives their position to be threatened by a lower-status group), resource scarcity (e.g., during periods of economic downturn or job scarcity), or with lack of deliberation (e.g., when overlooking long-term conditions or the perspectives of others; Davidai & Tepper, 2023). Scholars have recently begun to conceptualize zero-sum beliefs not only as a broad worldview, but as one that can be domain-specific, such that an individual's worldview may include one or a combination of domain-specific zero-sum beliefs (e.g., gender relations, race relations, LGBTQ+ rights, etc.; Davidai & Tepper, 2023). Importantly, zero-sum beliefs tend to work in tandem across multiple domains. A series of studies conducted by Fearon and Götz (2024) indicate that zero-sum beliefs are positively correlated across domains, such that one's beliefs about intergroup relations in one domain (e.g., race) can predict their beliefs about intergroup relations in another domain (e.g., gender). In their recent review of research, Davidai and Tepper (2023) note that, during times of changing power relations, those with domain-specific zero-sum beliefs may express that women's advances in social status result in men's loss of social status, Black Americans' gains in the workplace come at White Americans' loss of jobs, and that decreases in LGBTQ+ discrimination result in discrimination against Christians.

Although zero-sum beliefs are theoretically symmetrical (e.g., one party wins and one loses), there is evidence that individuals perceive them in an asymmetrical way. That is, individuals who hold zero-sum beliefs tend to believe the gains of others come at *their* party's expense, but *their own* party's gains come at the expense of no one (Roberts & Davidai, 2022; Wilkins et al., 2015). This could explain why zero-sum beliefs are more commonly held by individuals whose groups are relatively advantaged (Norton & Sommers, 2011; Stefaniak et al., 2020; Wilkins et al., 2015), as they have more to lose and less to gain than those who are disadvantaged. In fact, asymmetrical zero-sum beliefs are particularly common among people who perceive that their group is under threat (Roberts & Davidai, 2022).

Perhaps unsurprisingly, zero-sum beliefs have tangible implications for interpersonal and intergroup relations. Subscription to such beliefs is associated with pessimism, negative affect, decreased social engagement, loneliness, prejudice and discrimination, anti-egalitarianism, collective angst, and acts of dominance and aggression (Davidai & Tepper, 2023). Individuals who hold such beliefs are unlikely to ask for help from their peers due to the expectation that peers will not help them, and that asking would lower one's status (Davidai, 2025). Likewise, subscribing to zero-sum beliefs is associated with decreased willingness to help others, especially those from less advantaged groups (Chernyak-Hai & Davidai, 2022). For example, research has shown zero-sum belief endorsement to be negatively correlated with men's support for gender-fair work policies (Kuchynka et al., 2018). Additionally, this worldview is negatively associated with support for collective action or policies that aim to benefit Black Americans, and positively associated with support for pro-White policies to address perceived bias against White people (Stefaniak et al., 2020; Wellman et al., 2016; Wilkins et al., 2015). This is especially pronounced among White individuals who exhibit a strong sense of racial identity (Stefaniak et al., 2020).

Importantly, research on the zero-sum worldview tends to focus on power between groups rather than power within groups. This overlooks the grievances of less-advantaged members of generally privileged groups. One such group is incels, a Manosphere sect that we argue views themselves as victims of a zero-sum system, expressing anger that they are denied access to women's romantic and sexual subservience, which they believe men are warranted. In this sense, incels view themselves as subordinated men.

Incels' Weaponization of Subordination in a Zero-Sum Game

In the Manosphere, not all masculinities are equal. The Manosphere places high value on male privilege and the belief that men are entitled to women's subservience (Ging, 2019; Hoffman et al., 2020; Scaptura & Boyle, 2020). Users in the Manosphere endorse the concept of hegemonic masculinity, which positions the most privileged men (i.e., those who are White, straight, physically strong, conventionally attractive, financially successful, and sexually dominant with women) over less privileged men (Connell, 2005; Connell & Messerschmidt, 2005; Kalish & Kimmel, 2010; Kimmel, 2017).

By falling at the bottom of the masculine hierarchy, incels believe they are denied the privileges they are owed (e.g., sexual services of women), fostering a sense of "aggrieved entitlement," which refers to the anger attached to the belief

that the privileges to which one is entitled have been wrongfully denied (Kimmel, 2017). Incels react to this aggrieved entitlement with self-loathing, depression, suicidal ideation, and threats/acts of violence directed toward themselves or others (Ging, 2019; Hoffman et al., 2020; Ribeiro et al., 2021; Scaptura & Boyle, 2020). Incels define themselves as a subordinate group of "failed men" and they engage in the "weaponization of subordination," a practice whereby an individual uses their perceived subordinate status to legitimate the victimization of others (Halpin, 2022). This is consistent with the broader contemporary weaponization of victimhood by the privileged in which "claims to victimhood are claims to power" (Chouliaraki, 2024, p. 4).

According to Chouliaraki (2024), in a culture of victimhood, the *systemic* oppression of the underprivileged becomes equated with the *personal* pain experienced by those in privilege who feel their power is under threat. This is enacted by "populating public discourse with too many voices of pain while selectively amplifying the voices of the already powerful over those of the underprivileged" (p. 6). Such amplification of privileged voices "blur[s] the lines between systemic and tactical suffering," or between those who suffer institutional oppression and those who make claims of suffering for personal gain (p. 6). Among incels, the systemic objectification of women is equated with the individual aggrievement of men who do not reap direct benefits from this objectification, and the Manosphere provides a platform for elevating these personal claims of aggrievement.

Inceldom is a stigmatized masculine identity, and the ultimate goal is to exit through "ascension" or having sex with a woman. Goffman (1963) defined stigmatized identities as those characterized by attributes that distinguish an individual from others in a way that makes the individual less desirable, tainted, or discounted. According to Goffman, stigmatized identities "confirm the usualness of another" (p. 3), reifying the desirability of those whom Goffman called "normals," or those who adhere to social expectations. Thus, individuals with stigmatized identities often adopt strategies for managing stigma to curtail discrimination. Importantly, Goffman's original work did not examine the intergroup stigma that one may possess relative to a more privileged in-group of "normals" much less any subsequent feelings of aggrieved entitlement. Applied to the case at hand, incels belong to a privileged group based on their gender but they do not experience the full range of advantages typically allotted to this group due to their subordinate status on the masculine hierarchy.

Examining power disparities within privileged groups, Coston and Kimmel (2012) extended Goffman's work on stigmatized identities to explain the ways that gay men, working-class men, and men with disabilities strategically manage the problematization of their intersectional masculinities. As Coston and Kimmel note, these men use the strategies of *minstrelization* (i.e., exaggerating stereotypes about their group in an attempt to appear non-threatening), *normification* (i.e., exaggerating similarities and minimizing differences between themselves and the normals as a way to diminish any basis for discrimination), or *militant chauvinism* (i.e., maximizing differences from the dominant group in a way that makes themselves appear to be superior). According to Coston and Kimmel, men with stigmatized forms of masculine identity see "privilege where it isn't," using the aforementioned strategies to create the illusion of privilege that they do not possess.

Applying these strategies directly to incels, Andersen (2024) demonstrates how this group of men uses normification, minstrelization, and militant chauvinism to manage their stigmatized identities in a manner that either upholds, challenges, or rejects hegemonic masculinity. According to Andersen, incels who find hegemonic masculinity to be an attainable goal engage in normification, upholding hegemonic masculinity by discussing ways to improve their appearance ("looksmaxing" in incel parlance). These incels ultimately hope to "ascend" their stigmatized identities via sexual success with women.

Incels who believe hegemonic masculinity to be unachievable may either engage in minstrelization or militant chauvinism. Incels' adoption of minstrelization involves embracing their stigmatized identity and distancing themselves from hegemonic masculinity by circulating self- and group-deprecating narratives and promoting fatalism. These incels tend to promulgate violence against themselves such as by contemplating suicide or encouraging others in the community to end their own lives. Those who engage in militant chauvinism promote their own form of masculinity that they believe to be superior to hegemonic standards. This entails disparaging non-incels and reducing women to their perceived sexual value. Incels who employ militant chauvinism reject masculine norms and promote deterministic theories that advance their own superiority (e.g., claiming that they are the only men smart enough to see that women's sexual agency undermines men's evolutionary right to women's bodies), promoting violence against women and more powerful men as a means of rectifying their perceived victimhood.

We argue that, in line with Coston and Kimmel's (2012) analysis, the stigma management strategies outlined by Andersen (2024) each entail incels seeing privilege where it does not exist, either by separating oneself from a stigmatized identity or by embracing/valorizing a stigmatized identity. While incels certainly see privilege where it does not exist, we posit that they also create inequality where it does not exist. Building from a sense of aggrieved entitlement

(Kimmel, 2017), incels are known to engage in self-deprecation and hold feminism accountable for their perceived inferiority (Ging, 2019; Hoffman et al., 2020; Ribeiro et al., 2021; Scaptura & Boyle, 2020). As Halpin (2022) argues, incels exhibit the "weaponization of subordination," using their perceived inequality as justification for the victimization of others. We argue that this weaponization of subordination reflects a zero-sum mindset intertwined with aggrieved entitlement in which incels view intragroup gender privilege experienced by more powerful men as coming at their personal expense. Thus, in our analysis, we explore the following research question: How do incels construct inequality in the Manosphere?

Method

To answer this research question, we conducted a netnography (i.e., internet ethnography), which Kozinets (2020) conceptualizes as following an operational praxis to understand cultural meaning within the realm of social media through the "active intellectual and emotional engagement with online sites" (p. 136). This praxis includes six procedures: (1) initiation, (2) investigation, (3) immersion, (4) interaction, (5) integration, and (6) incarnation. Below, we address each of these six procedures, followed by a discussion of our efforts to ensure data trustworthiness throughout our research process.

Initiation and Ethics

Initiation provides investigatory direction through the development of a guiding research question and consideration of any ethical issues in addressing that research question. We initiated our study by developing a research question that was grounded in the extant literature, as described above. We also considered the ethical issues of conducting social media research. Based on consultation with the first author's Institutional Review Board (IRB), our study does not meet the federal definition of human subjects research and was excluded from review. Yet, the use of social media content for research is the source of ongoing ethical debate regarding whether informed consent and assurances of confidentiality are necessary, or even possible (see Golder et al., 2017, for a review). Thus, we followed the guidance of Moreno et al. (2013), which indicates our study meets the definition of observational research (i.e., we retrospectively collected posts without interacting with participants) and does not involve human subjects (i.e., data were unidentifiable and publicly available). This assuages concerns surrounding confidentiality and participant consent. However, to ensure that posts could not be easily traced to any specific incels.is user, we omitted usernames from our analysis.

Of specific pertinence to researching a group known to promote violence, the second author reported any content that explicitly discussed plans to harm others or included inappropriate sexual content about minors to the Internet Crime Complaint Center, the Federal Bureau of Investigation, and/or the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children. While incel forums also contain content about planned acts of harm towards the users themselves (such as suicidal ideation), we did not report this content, as currently, in the United States, there is no way to report anonymous planned intention of self-harm to a government agency outside of local law enforcement.

Investigation

The process of investigation entails mapping the netnographic landscape to identify online data sources that are appropriate for the research question. Studying incels' online activity has become complicated in recent years, as many incel forums have been banned due to members' threats of violence (Gillett & Suzor, 2022). Examples of such banned forums include Reddit groups such as r/Incels, r/braincels, and r/IncelsWithoutHate. Other active incel forums are inappropriate for analysis because they do not represent actively engaged incels, being either tailored to incels who wish to break away from the community (i.e., r/IncelExit) or circulating ideology that is largely consistent with that of the incel community while explicitly rejecting the incel label (i.e., r/ForeverAlone).

We focused our netnography on incels.is. Following the banning of several incel Reddit forums, incels.is has arguably become the most active incel forum. Defining itself as "a forum for involuntary celibates," incels.is boasted approximately 34,000 members as of 2025, with approximately 20 million posts. Since the banning of other forums, incels.is has become prominently discussed and analyzed in the scholarly literature (for examples, see Costello & Buss, 2023; Davis & Kettrey, 2024; Gillett & Suzor, 2022; Halpin, 2022; O'Donnell & Shor, 2022).

Immersion in the Context of Researcher Positionality

During immersion, the most intense process of netnography, the researchers inhabit the online environment to collect/index data, placing emphasis on quality over quantity. To achieve immersion, we inhabited the incels.is environment for a roughly two-year period between 2023 and 2025. Immersion was a cumulative process that included data

collection for our previous research, which began in January of 2023, as well as a subsequent prolonged immersion for the current analysis. Like traditional ethnographic research, the immersive nature of netnography often involves unstructured data collection methods. As Hammersley and Atkinson (2007) explain, the "exploratory character of ethnographic research means that it will often not be clear where, within a setting, observation should begin" (p. 4). Thus, data collection in ethnographic research typically involves some situational selection and decision-making by the researchers. Rather than operating within a definitive sampling frame, ethnographic researchers may make decisions about the relevance of an observation when they encounter it in the research setting. Ultimately, the selectivity process of ethnographic data collection means that "some features of the setting will be given no attention at all, and even those phenomena that are the major focus will be looked at in a way that by no means exhausts their characteristics" (Hammersley & Atkinson, 2007, p. 32). This is particularly the case for netnographic research, as the scope of data in digital spaces can be so vast that it precludes the identification of a definitive sampling frame (Kozinets, 2020; Mpofu, 2025). As Kozinets (2020) explains:

> The term "selectivity" is important because the act of collecting data happens as particular pieces of information are chosen to be part of a project, and then processed in the act of interpretation during the attempt to build knowledge and uncover scientific truths. (p. 191)

Instead of identifying a circumscribed sample of posts from a vast and nebulous sampling frame, we immersed ourselves in the incels.is forum and explored it the way that a typical user might. This included reviewing the site rules/FAQs and navigating through the extensive threads (incels.is does not have a search feature, thus users must manually navigate the forum's content). Following the guidance of Kozinets (2020), we kept notes on the paths taken and not taken through the forum (e.g., following discussions that revealed information about inequality) as well as our interpretations of the content we encountered (see our discussion of data coding in the "Integration and Incarnation" section below). At the conclusion of our immersion and data coding process, toward the end of 2025, we returned to the incels.is forum and captured approximately 130 pages of screenshots of posts that were representative of the codes we extracted from our notes.

Throughout the immersion process, we critically reflected on our actions, assumptions, and potential biases that may have influenced our selection and interpretation of data. Emphasizing the importance of reflexivity in ethnographic research, Davies (2012) argues that no researcher is completely isolated from the setting they study – and that the products of research are influenced by the social position of researchers as well as their process of doing research. We fully believe that our immersion experience was affected by our positionality. Both authors are White, cisgender, straight women who have conducted previous research on the Manosphere, a highly misogynistic space where violence against women is often lauded and normalized. The rules for posting to incels.is explicitly state that women and LGBTQ+ people are not allowed as members (i.e., "Banned on sight, no exceptions. This is a heterosexual male-only forum"). Navigating a hostile space where women are targeted with hatred resembled a bit of a gaslighting experience, and during our regular debriefing meetings we not only compared research observations/notes but also made an intentional point of reflecting on our subjective responses to this environment as well as the ways that these responses may influence the research process (as described by Campbell's, 2013, account of emotional responses to researching trauma).

We continued our immersion process until we approached a point of data saturation, which Glaser and Strauss (1967) conceptualize as the point at which researchers observe no additional data for building theoretical concepts. Specific to ethnographic research, data saturation typically means that researchers can generate a detailed description of the culture they are studying (Moser & Korstjens, 2018). The vastness of social media forum data can make assessment of saturation difficult and, thus, Mpofu (2025) recommends defining saturation in digital contexts as "the point where iterative data collection and analysis yields diminishing returns in discovering new themes, insights or meanings, while providing sufficiently robust and representative findings to address.. . the research objectives" (p. 13). Thus, we immersed ourselves in incels.is until we decided we could adequately describe the culture on the forum as it pertains to the construction of inequality, which is the focus of our study's research question.

Interaction

Interaction entails direct engagement with online participants; however, Kozinets (2020) notes that this is only necessary when, after immersion, "particular topics that are important to the investigation still allude" the researchers (p. 141). In other words, interaction is an optional process for seeking clarification and/or in-depth understanding from a netnography when such understanding is not yielded by immersion. We initially obtained IRB approval to recruit participants from incel forums to complete an open-ended survey, but our recruitment efforts were unsuccessful.

With women being prohibited from posting to incels.is, we approached moderators of incel-tangent forums (e.g., forums that do not identify as incel, but espouse ideology that is congruent with incel ideology), however, moderators rejected our requests. This difficulty (for women researchers) in recruiting incel participants into human subjects research is consistent with what we have gathered from our correspondences with researchers who have made similar attempts. Although our research may have been enhanced by collecting data from individual members of the incel community, we believe the contextualized data we collected from our immersion in the online community was sufficient to address our research question.

Integration and Incarnation

Integration is the process of interpreting and analyzing data; in a netnography, this is an iterative process that researchers continually perform and refine while immersed in the study environment (Kozinets, 2020). Our ongoing data analysis followed a modified grounded theory framework (Glaser & Strauss, 1967), as described by Charmaz (2014). During the immersion process, we kept detailed notes on *initial codes* pertinent to our research question. These initial codes describe minute themes that are "provisional, comparative, and grounded in the data" (p. 177). During regular meetings, we synthesized salient initial codes into *focused codes*, or categories that provided interpretive value to the larger themes the initial codes formed. In the final stages of our analysis, we elevated these focused code categories to a theoretical level by proposing an overarching concept that gives "abstract understanding more priority than explanation" (p. 230). This theoretical concept subsumes, and shows relationships between the focused code categories, rendering meaning between the focused codes. Coding was collaborative and all disagreements were resolved via discussion.

It is important to note that the anonymous nature of social media forums precludes certainty about the identity, sincerity, or motivation of those who are posting content. To address this uncertainty, Kozinets (2020) recommends that researchers consider the social media forum, rather than individual users, to be the unit of analysis. Thus, in our analysis, we examine the collective process of constructing inequality on incels.is. We interpret posts as relaying important information about the ways users build collective meaning and signal that they belong to the group without making assumptions about individual users' personal beliefs.

In our presentation of findings, we relay our theoretical concept and underlying focused codes, achieving incarnation, which Kozinets (2020) describes as the communication of findings in a way that clearly addresses the research question. We are careful to relay forum content in its original form. Except for bracketed edits made to define incel lexicon or improve readability, the grammar, spelling, and punctuation all appear in their original form. The quotes that we include to illustrate our findings contain extreme and explicit content, but we believe these quotes to be representative of the general content posted to incels.is. Although there is variation in the tone and explicitness of rhetoric circulated on incel forums, this variation tends to be more pronounced between forums rather than within forums, with incels.is being the most popular and explicit (Davis & Kettrey, 2024). While many quotes may seem striking to the reader, they are intended to exemplify content that a typical user or lurker would quickly encounter when visiting this forum.

Data Trustworthiness

Throughout our netnography, we were careful to ensure data trustworthiness, which entails credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability (Lincoln & Guba, 1985). To ensure credibility, which pertains to the truth of findings, we engaged in a prolonged (two-year) immersion. This enabled us to develop proficient comprehension of the nuanced vernacular circulated on incels.is as well as move beyond the initial shock of encountering extreme content on the forum, habituating in a way that allowed us to engage in deep analysis of subtleties conveyed through users' comments. To achieve transferability, understood as the potential for findings to apply to contexts beyond the one we studied, we used a coding process (described in our discussion of "Integration and Incarnation") that moved beyond the descriptive and toward the theoretical. Specifically, in our analysis, we propose an overarching theoretical concept that we anticipate may generalize to other lower-status members of privileged groups.

To demonstrate dependability, defined as consistency of findings, we collaborated throughout the coding process (described in our discussion of "Integration and Incarnation"). During collaborative meetings, we audited each other's coding, discussing any disagreements until we arrived at a consensus on meaning. Confirmability, which pertains to researcher neutrality or bias, was a key consideration in our analysis. We addressed this in detail through our discussion of research positionality, which appears above.

Results

Our examination of incels' construction of victimhood highlights the ways that this group equates their personal pain with the systemic oppression of the underprivileged

Table 1 Focused and Initial Codes That Construct Zeroing Out in an Incel Forum

Initial code	Description	Example quote
Focused Code: Inceldom as Disability		
Undesirable Physical Traits	Incels framing themselves as having a disability based on undesirable physical traits.	"Its not your fault u havent talked to a whore thou. A girl will never go out of their way to talk or contact a sub5 [less than five on a scale of physical attractiveness]. So If u 'try' to talk to a fkn female in her mind ur harassing her."
Neurodivergence	Incels framing themselves as having a disability based on neurodivergence.	"You have to be NT [neurotypical] if you're a man…. Doesn't matter how much you fake it, people can sense it."
Evolutionary Failure	Incels framing themselves as constituting an evolutionary failure who will not be able to have sex with a woman and continue his bloodline.	"All foids [female humanoids] care is about your genetic looks and if you don't have that any change you try to make in your personality is completely pointless."
Focused Code: Inceldom as Marginalized Sexual Identity		
"Kissless" Collective Identity	Incels defining themselves as a group that is attracted to women who will never be attracted to them.	"Liking girls is so irritating cuz it's just not something that I can control but then they probably won't ever like you back. Ugh I hate this feeling."
Boundary Work	Incels determining who is an authentic insider and who is an outsider to the group.	"I've been thinking about the black-pill even more and more now. It is seriously over for all of us. Now i'm not talking about you 6–8 normans [normal guys] i'm talking about TRUECells [true incels]. The ones that were put at a disadvantage they day they were born. FACE rules all. you either have it or you don't. Chads [alpha men] are not made they are born."
Systemic Oppression	Incels describing the loneliness they experience as a form of structural inequality.	"Do you know why the marriage market is in the current situation? Because we, as men, are unable to organize ourselves and have been left to play the game like little children. The problem is systemic, and for anyone to pay attention, we need to be organized and disrupt the ruling class enough to make it a problem for them. We need organization and action."
Focused Code: Inceldom as Uprising		
Reparations	Incels demanding compensation for their grievance that they have not received the sexual privileges they believe they are owed.	"I don't really want a movement, I just want free euthanasia available for anyone aged 21 and up so I don't have to look like this anymore. There's no amount of movements that would ever make people respect us and want us around."
Vengeance	Incels plotting violent retribution to address their grievance that they have not received the sexual privileges they believe they are owed.	"It turns out that killing people is an effective way to elicit the attention of many women: virtually every serial killer, including Ted Bundy, Charles Manson, and David Berkowitz, have received love letters from large numbers of female fans."
Charismatic Incels	Incels evoking and/or glorifying charismatic incels who have executed mass acts of violence to address their grievance that they have not received the sexual privileges they believe they are owed.	"I want to be a parasite and pain to this society, making it wishforced [sic] euthanasia was a thing, just as saint ER [Elliot Rodger] did and wanted."

(Chouliaraki, 2024). Although incels consistently cast themselves as personal victims of women's collective gains (in a manner consistent with Chouliaraki's observations), we also found that they appropriated the identity of marginalized groups that have demonstrated success in bringing visibility to their societal disadvantage. Specifically, our focused codes demonstrate that incels.is users cast inceldom as a *disability* and a *marginalized sexual identity*. Incels use these castings to call for an *uprising* to secure reparations to address their aggrievement for not receiving the masculine privilege they believe they are owed (see Table 1 for a summary of focused codes and their underlying initial codes). We call incels' appropriation of marginalized identities *zeroing out*, which we define as the strategic adoption of systemic inequality in a way that appropriates the experiences of the underprivileged for the purpose of securing the entitlements one feels owed, but denied, as a lower-status member of a privileged group.

It is important to note that incels.is users overwhelmingly conveyed a sense of intellectual and moral superiority (e.g., the belief that they possess special knowledge regarding societal gender dynamics). However, this self-ascribed superiority does not negate their belief that they are systemically oppressed. In fact, the disparity between their perceived intelligence and oppression serves to amplify their claims of injustice. In our analysis, we conceptualize incels' construction of inceldom as a disability and marginalized sexual identity as an illustration of zeroing out, with the call for an uprising as the proposed solution to this perceived marginalization. In other words, appropriating marginalized

identities is the process and calling for an uprising is the product of zeroing out. Thus, we order our findings to reflect this pattern.

Inceldom as Disability

Users posting to incels.is described themselves as being disadvantaged in ways that are similar to the experiences of individuals with disabilities. This was evident through incels' discussion of the belief that undesirable physical attributes and neurodivergence make them unattractive to women in a way that constitutes a form of evolutionary failure, prohibiting them from having sex with a woman and continuing their bloodline.

Users commonly disparaged their physical traits in a fleeting and matter-of-fact manner. For example, one user simply stated, "Nothing is worse than a unique face, I sadly have one" and another lamented he is an "unlucky guy" and that "a few millimeters of facial bone would have made everything different." The mundane way users disparaged their physical appearance illustrates the extent to which dissatisfaction with one's appearance is held as a baseline incel trait. For example, one user posted, "Trucel [true incel] trait: You have trash-tier genetics. Not only do I have an sub5 [below five on a 10-point scale of attractiveness] face, I also have a lousy physique – I'm very skinny with thin bones. To give you an idea, my wrist is less than 6" (the average male wrist is 7)."

In addition to disparaging their physical appearance, incels often described themselves as neurodivergent, sometimes with evidence suggesting a formal diagnosis and sometimes seemingly through self-diagnosis. This is consistent with past research, which suggests that incels have high rates of official and/or self-diagnosis of autism relative to the general population (Moskalenko et al., 2022). One recent study demonstrated that incels use ableism as a "tool to blame women, justify their resentment, promote networked misogyny, and hence reinforce their worldview" (Gheorghe & Clement, 2024, pp. 904–905). In other words, incels circulate claims that women reject them based on their neurodivergence, using such claims to justify sexism and encourage violence against women. In our analysis we saw examples of incels alleging not only that women reject them based on their neurodivergence, but also that neurodivergent women do not experience this same form of rejection. They then used this perceived disparity as evidence of systemic oppression against incels. In a post titled "Being an autistic truecel is so brutal," one user expressed:

> Being nd [neurodivergent] literally makes everything in life 10x harder. I haven't made a single friend my entire life, likely will never have a family.. . Everywhere I go i literally just get treated like a subhuman.. .. I literally don't know what it is about people being able to detect you have something wrong with you so quickly.. .. I'm practically below subhuman at this point.

Asking whether women can "smell autism," one user who described being diagnosed at age 13 commented, "I don't think I struggle socially with other men but I think women can sense something is 'off'?" He continued to explain that his female classmates treat him like a pet and aren't attracted to him, explaining:

> I hate them so much. It's been this way since middle school and I don't think anyone is gonna want me because they just infantilize me because they sense my autism. Just because I'm retarded doesn't mean I want to be treated as your pet fag.

Users expressed the belief that physical appearance and neurodivergence disadvantage them both socially and economically. Yet, they did not see women facing similar consequences for comparable traits. In response to the question, "Does the shape of your eyelids or chin for example affect your ability to do your job?" one user answered "yeah, cos HR departments are often filled with foids [female humanoids] and they rate job applicants based on photos" and then pondered, "imagine if people called foids useless trash for having small boobs."

One common point of discussion was the assertion that women are better able to mask neurodivergent traits and/or compensate for neurodivergence with physical attractiveness in ways that men cannot. One user explained:

> If autistic women are not better at reading social cues than autistic men, then why are they better able to function in modern society? Why are they much more likely to pass on their genes than autistic men? The answer is simple: attractiveness. Most autistic women are at least somewhat attractive to the opposite sex, and the attractiveness halo effect causes men to view their autistic traits more positively.

Another user claiming to be neurodivergent lamented that neurodivergent women "get to be seen as cute and quirky.. . but they're still hypergamous af [as fuck]. .. while ignoring all the lonely autistic men around them.. . we [autistic men] are rightfully angry at being tossed away by society."

Users frequently described their physical appearance and neurodivergence in terms of evolutionary failure, bemoaning that they will not be able to reproduce with a woman and their gene pool will be halted. One user succinctly

explained, the "only way to save incels is to never be born, ugly short people should be prevented from breeding from this time onwards." Some saw this evolutionary failure as part of a larger conspiracy by feminists and more sexually successful men. Posing the question, "Do you believe in mate suppression?" one user theorized:

> Mate suppression is exactly what it says. .. it's suppressing other people's chances of finding mates and reproducing. It's not a theory that's as well known as the great replacement, but if you look around you, in our current SOYciety [society defined by effeminate men], it's pretty obvious.

This user continued by explaining that mate suppression is driven by feminism, which "actively encourages misandry and tells women not to have children" and by simps (i.e., men who show unreciprocated affection for women) who misguidedly adhere to a "moral code of 'protecting da wimminz' from men." He concluded, "women were given the right to choose their partners, when they didn't have this in the past, and for a good reason. So every man can have an easier chance at ascending [having sex with a woman]."

Critiquing a shared (external) post attributed to "toxic femininity" and titled "Incels don't exist in nature, so why should they exist in humans?" users responded with a mix of rape/death threats, comments indicating that "foid rights" don't exist in nature, and descriptions of incels as evolutionary failures who will never reproduce or make a contribution to the gene pool. As an example of the latter, one user argued, "They don't think about WHY incels don't exist in nature. Incel animals either rape/coerce/pressure their foid counterparts into letting them reproduce, or they suffer and die. The only option they really want for us if simply suffering and/or death." Another user embedded a threat of violence into an evolutionary argument, stating, "If natural selection tries to remove you from the gene pool, you should remove the gene pool as much as possible in return."

This evolutionary failure and inability to continue one's gene pool was seen as unsurmountable, even through sexual violence. In a post titled, "Let's face it, even if rape was legal, we probably would still be incels," one user explained:

> From what ive seen so far, a lot of us probably would not be able to overpower an adult foid who we want to make love to/hate-rape them.. .. a guy needs to be really strong and tall if he wants to pull off a rape against an adult foid who isnt intoxicated. His dick needs to be massive so the walls of a foids pussy are torn and bruised, which causes enough shock to prevent her from fighting back.. .. A lot of us have physical conditions that hinder our strength, have mental problems that ruin our energy, and are quite physically small which means we wont be able to pull off a rape.

As expressed here, the disability-like status of incels makes it impossible for them to find mates and reproduce, essentially constituting an evolutionary failure. As a potential solution, this incel proposes forced sexual assault, which he ironically believes he is incapable of committing due to his physical failures as an incel.

Inceldom as Marginalized Sexual Identity

In addition to equating their experiences with the disadvantages that are experienced by persons with disabilities, incels.is users described themselves in ways that seemingly adopted a marginalized sexual identity. One's sexual identity may be broadly defined by their romantic and/or sexual attraction to others; incels explicitly defined themselves as being attracted to women who will never be attracted to them. Referring to themselves as "kissless," "dateless," and "sexless" was foundational to incels' collective sense of being and they saw themselves as both internally tormented and systemically oppressed by their sexual identity.

In a thread titled, "I hate liking girls," users expressed grievances that "it's brutal knowing you want to fuck foids while also knowing you never will" and "our very instincts bring us pain. All we can do is try not to think about it." In a thread titled, "Why are you incel?" one user listed the following: "Im kissless virgin dateless[.] Cannot maintain any relationship.. .. Been rejected all the times I try." Another explained, "I am invisible to all women. I am a ghost that nobody sees.. .. If you are not a pretty boy or a hot guy, women will ignore you. They won't see past your looks." In a more elaborate post, one user explained that he is:

> Inexperienced and therefore bad in bed and romantic relationships.. .. I'm just not good enough for women, I'm not good enough to do something as normal and commonly practiced nowadays as having sex, I'm a subhuman and I'm inferior, I hate myself.

In their grievances, incels cast themselves as sexual minorities at a disadvantage relative to the majority: sexually experienced men and women. Comparing incels to what he called "sex haver men," one user lamented, "Men who have sex and date are always outgoing, confident, energetic, making a lot of jokes, etc. Those single/virgin men always seem to have this melancholy vibe about them that's subtle, as if they're trying to cope." Another agreed:

> Yeah. love is simply one of the human needs. You can't be truly happy if you're cold or hungry, neither can

> you be truly happy if you're unloved. You can survive but you can't prosper. People who preach the ability to live happily without sex, are having sex themselves. It's a mockery.

Incels.is users engaged in significant boundary work to signify who was an authentic insider and who was an outsider. They expressed derision toward outsiders who appropriated their identity and lexicon. As one expressed:

> I see more and more normies [average men] using terms like "mogging" [outshining someone], "rope" [suicide], "blackpill" [nihilist awakening to society's purported bias against men] etc that were coined by us. Now all this has been stolen from us by chads [alpha men] and normies. Of course, all normies laugh at an ugly guy.. . and call him incel as an insult.. .. . The worst part is that all this [knowledge that the] incel community has shared for years has become a literal tiktok meme because of retarded teenagers. It worries me that I see more and more normies calling themselves "incels" as a joke despite having girlfriends.

Boundary work also entailed identifying those who might ascend or exit the incel community after having sex with a woman. At times, living with the sexual rejection of women was expressed as an inevitable and immutable part of incel identity. As one explained, no matter how hard an incel tries to gain the attention of a woman:

> Women will still Blame you for not getting a gf [girlfriend], it's all your fault, according to foids. They think you are the bad guy for wanting a love from a woman. Wanting a girlfriend is toxic and means you are a negative person, says the foids on reddit. Don't waste your time trying to ascend, all of it false hope. It's like a person throwing a coin in the water fountain and hoping that he will win the lottery in the future. If you have incel looks, and you believe that God will save you from inceldom or that being confident will get you laid, you are a fool.

In a thread titled, "Which users will ascend sooner or later?" users attempted to identify potential outsiders who were not permanent members of the community. In the words of one user, "If we analyse every .is users who has ascended we can probably predict which fakecels [fake incels] are polluting this forum with their presence.. . No love for anyone who succeeds and leaves truecels back in the dirt." After other users produced lists of incels who have ascended, the original poster declared, "they need to be reported, mockery of our condition shall not be tolerated." Expressing the presumed inevitability of never receiving the attention of a woman, another user conceded, "Its a bitter pill to swollow but once you accept it[,] it does get easier you just adapt to your new reality also try being more materialistic and shallow is my only real advice."

Users not only expressed internal torment associated with the incel identity; they also saw their sexual identity as a source of systemic oppression and persecution. Comments on incels.is suggested users believe their lack of sexual success with women constitutes a deprivation of basic human rights. As one user declared:

> I feel like my human rights are violated as an Incel. Even if one may argue I'm not "entitled" to a toilet [woman]... [ellipses in original] I'm still (1) Entitled to solicit a prostitute if I want (2) Entitled to keep my money and not have it taxed to go to single mothers (3) Entitled to not have my money used to subsidize toilets who otherwise would go into prostitution (4) Be forbidden from speaking my mind without being cancelled by a government funded institution.

The loneliness that incels experience was described as a broad form of oppression and torture. In a post titled "Inceldom is basically solitary confinement on a massive scale," one user argued:

> In jails/prison, the most dangerous/bad convicts are isolated from the rest of the population into solitary confinement cells. Which is literal torture btw [by the way]. Social isolation is one of the most brutal, cheap and effective torture methods. Inceldom means being socially isolated from the rest because of lookism [appearance-based prejudice]. Yet normies and foids blame us for being locked in solitary FUCK THIS SHIT.

Some blamed this purported deprivation of rights as justification for hate, violence, and unlawful sexual activity. For example, comments about sex with minors were common. In a post titled, "Lonely men are more likely to pursue romantic or sexual connections with minors," one user argued, "If we want to reduce the number of minors that get chatted up then not creating a society with huge numbers of desperately lonely men would be a really, really good start." This comment insinuates that unlawful sexual activity with minors is a product of the systemic oppression of incels.

In the incels.is community, underage girls were viewed as useful for fulfilling the basic "rights" of incels and, thus, were believed to be unfairly prohibited as sexual partners. Incels.is users assigned a particularly high sexual market value to underage girls, describing them as preferable to

women over the age of 18 because they are more impressionable and controllable. In contrast, they assigned low "sexual market value" and, thus low human value, to lesbians. Users expressed a particularly strong hatred of lesbians, whom they viewed as being invaluable to fulfilling the desires of incels. That is, due to their lack of sexual desire for men, lesbians were perceived as being disposable. In an illustrative thread framed by the question, "What should society do with lesbians?" one user opined:

> They are objectively worthless. They offer nothing to society. What should be done with them? Slave labor? Thrown into a meat grinder and turned to pig feed? Skinned alive on live TV and left crucified in the streets to strike fear into foids? Lmk [let me know] what you think.

This question generated responses from multiple users surmising how they might dispose of lesbians, including "Burn them alive," "I advocate for The Handmaid's Tale example: cutting off clitoris and zipping up vaginas," "force them to take incel cock," "B[r]ing back the Salem Witch Trials. Why'd we get rid of them again?" and "Beat them with crowbars until they beg for cock, then get raped."

This marked violent disdain for lesbians, which was pronounced in this forum, is ironic considering that incels seemed to see themselves as oppressed based on their sexuality. Although incels.is users seemingly defined themselves as belonging to a sexual minoritized group, they clearly distinguished themselves from the LGBTQ+ community. Forum rules explicitly prohibit LGBTQ+ individuals from being members, declaring "this is a heterosexual male-only forum." Additionally, users frequently posted anti-LGBTQ+ slurs to disparage LGBTQ+ individuals as well as to denigrate or emasculate straight men who were outsiders to the incel community. While incels appropriated the experiences of oppression faced by LGBTQ+ individuals in many ways, they did not see themselves as allies to this community. Thus, it is not surprising that incels expressed the need to build their own movement or incite their own uprising to obtain the reparations they believe are owed to them.

Inceldom as Uprising

As previously discussed, incels.is users engaged in the process of zeroing out by equating their experiences with those of marginalized and oppressed groups. Yet, they did not align themselves with these groups culturally or politically. Rather, they viewed themselves as being wrongfully relegated to the very bottom rung of society and expressed a need for their own movement to incite action and secure reparations. In fact, users discussed existing movements, such as those aiming for gender or racial equality, with derision. For example, one user declared, "Metoo and Wokeness made women a liability. Just like ni[***r] lives matter made people avoid black people because they dont want to be called racist. They force their shit on us and won[d]er why especially young men dont like it."

Refusing to ally themselves with the groups whose marginalization they appropriate, incels proposed their own solutions to their perceived marginalization – or to their zeroed-out status. Although offering no clear or organized plan of action, users expressed entitlement to reparations for the rejection they face from women. Potential reparations included legalized prostitution, legalized rape, removal of women's voting rights, lowered age of sexual consent (to make minors available), and government assignment of wives to all men. In a thread titled, "Deprived of my male right is oppression," a user lamented:

> What else do I have testes and a penis for, other than to fill my seed in a girl? My anatomy has gone to waste because foids have comical standards. So my dick and balls just hang and are cruelly banned from any intimacy. Legalize escorts, and the government should increase neetbux [funds for those "Not in Employment, Education, or Training"] and fund surrogacy.

This user likened inceldom to a marginalized sexual identity by insinuating that he has been deprived of a basic human right to sexual intimacy. His proposed solutions include government action to make women more sexually available and to increase the general quality of life among those men who are not attractive to women.

Just as users appropriated the general status of marginalized groups, they also appropriated the words of their leaders. A thread titled, "Incels should have our own political movement" borrowed from Martin Luther King, Jr.'s famous speech by opening with the iconic phrase, "I HAVE A DREAM," and prophesizing:

> I think that every man in this wonderful country should have the right to have a wife to be complete with himself, because what is a man without a woman? what is he? A degenerate. We incels are many but our voice has been muffled by the shame of being mocked and the taboo of the society that discriminates [against] us.

This user continued by listing demands of the "incel movement" as follows: "the state provides 1 wife for each incel," public and commercial services provide "preferential treatment [to incels] for being born with bad genes," there should be a "quota of incels in every company in order to free us from the hierarchical oppression," and "insulting an

incel with 'manlet' or 'ugly' [should] be illegal." Interestingly, after opening his proclamation with the language of a civil rights icon who charismatically led a nonviolent movement, this user then warned that if any of these demands are not met then incels "will be forced to start protests, destroy businesses, loot cities to free ourselves from the oppression of being ignored, our voices will not be shut down anymore." Such incitement of violence was a marked point of departure from the largely nonviolent collective efforts of the marginalized groups to whom incels likened themselves.

Acts of vengeance were widely, although not unanimously, accepted on this forum such that calls to action mirrored an uprising more so than an organized movement. Rationalizing the use of violence as a solution to their zeroed-out status, one user argued, "the term '*incel violence'* [emphasis in original] has become a convenient headline grabber-compressing complex psychological and societal dynamics into a lazy meme." After describing the purported oppression of mass shooters such as Elliot Rodger (Isla Vista shooter) and Adam Lanza (Sandy Hook Elementary School shooter) who were ostensibly "denied writing career support" and suffered from "total educational and social isolation," respectively, the user urged readers to "stop blaming 'incels'" and "start acknowledging systemic cruelty." This user then concluded "there is no singular 'incel ideology' causing violence-there's rejection culture, amplified through lookism unanswered trauma, and broken institutional systems."

As illustrated in the previous quote, incels.is users lauded and glorified charismatic incel leaders who rose to public infamy by committing acts of mass violence. Praising Bryan Kohberger, a purported incel who pleaded guilty to killing four University of Idaho students in 2022, one user exalted:

> Bryan kohberger was a hero who removed disgusting roasties [comparing sexually experienced women's labia to roast beef] from this planet. No matter how much normies seethe these girls are never coming back to life. They're dead forever.. .. bryan kohberger, Eliot [sic] Rodger, Cho, Peka, Alek, Clark, Paramonov. All heroes who sacrificed their lives to remove the female parasite from this planet.

Other users responded affirmatively with succinct messages such as, "He's a hero. May he live on," "Free him," and "free that brother." Still, others more explicitly condemned the victims of incel violence (e.g., "Alek Minassian and Bryan Kohberger are probably only 2 alive 'incel killers' they did nothing wrong imo [in my opinion] that they killed these disgusting foids free them."), some while elevating mass murderers to martyrdom (e.g., "Even if they kill him [Kohberger] he will ascend to Incellhalla [place of incel heroes] while all women rot in hell").

Elliot Rodger, known as the "Supreme Gentleman" or "Saint Elliot" was the most commonly invoked. A user displaying a photo of Elliot Rodger as his avatar described how he was captivated by Rodger's 2014 killing of six people and injury of fourteen others in a mass act of violence preceded by a manifesto that was an early influence on the incel community. As he recalled:

> When I was a kid.. .. I heard the news anchor announce yet another mass shooting in the United States. I walked over to the screen. The report was about the Isla Vista shooting. At that moment, they showed a clip from Elliot's final video. And then…[ellipses in original] something weird happened. When his face appeared on the screen, I had the feeling he was looking straight at me. Not like someone looking into a camera, no, it felt like he actually saw me. I felt this chill run through my body, like a cold wave, electric almost. A second later came a slight dizziness. It was quick, but intense.. .. looking back… [ellipses in original] it really unsettles me. Especially now, seeing how much my current life strangely mirrors his.

In another thread titled, "new saint dropped," a user described a case where a man was arrested for allegedly killing a woman who told him she wanted to be friends and was not interested in a romantic or sexual relationship. Users responded by lauding lethal violence against women (i.e., "She was keeping him in the friendzone for boyfriend perks without the sex I don't blame him" or "Good riddance whore") and/or framing the event as routine and unexceptional. Many of these responses emphasized the letters ER (i.e., Elliot Rodger) when embedded in mundane language: "anothER saturday" and "his pERsonality (aka his bone structure) wasnt confid[e]nt enough to make her grant him her pussy." Emphasizing the letters ER explicitly condones violence and exalts Rodger, as invoking Rodger's initials (e.g., "going ER") is synonymous with threatening violence in the incel community.

While users disagreed regarding whether an organized political movement or violent uprising is necessary to secure equality for incels, there was a common nihilistic understanding that some form of action is warranted and/or inevitable as a solution to their perceived marginalization. In one illustrative post, a user framed incels as the single group capable of uniting men across diverse social domains against the social ills purportedly created by women's sexuality. This user optimistically postulated:

> I remember not too long ago, that someone made a thread where he described inceldom as the first movement/group to unite men of all races, religions and political ideologies. When I was contemplating this recently, I realized something about history: when you come down to it, every single conflict between men in history was caused by the hypergamous nature of women.

He continued to explain that women have incited nationalism by "intermixing with other races," socialism by denying lower-class men the right to "marry or otherwise gain a sexual partner," and religious uprisings by gaining rights and "opportunities to be whores." He then surmised:

> So basically, all ideologies exist purely for sub-8 men [men who are ranked lower than an 8 on a 10-point scale of attractiveness] to increase the chance of gaining a sexual partner and all ideological conflicts were essentially a struggle to regain control over women, who naturally lack any form of loyalty for men that aren't Chad [alpha male]. If women were inherently loyal and not hypergamous, many of the major wars of history would not have happened and men of all races and creeds could live together in peace.

Here, this user not only constructed inceldom as a marginalized identity but also insinuated that men, and incels in particular, are the prototypical victims of oppression, with women as prototypical oppressors. The logic that incels are fundamentally oppressed reflects the process of zeroing out and explains incels' refusal to ally themselves with marginalized groups, as they believe these groups to be more advantaged than themselves. Thus, zeroing out further isolates this group, leaving them to propose their own drastic solutions to perceived injustices.

Discussion

In a zero-sum game, resources are viewed as finite and the gains of one group are believed to come at the expense of another (Davidai & Tepper, 2023). Yet, existing research on the zero-sum worldview has largely focused on perceptions of power between groups rather than within groups. Research on masculinities has demonstrated that men who do not possess a great deal of masculine privilege (e.g., working class men, gay men, those with disabilities) may actively work to construct privilege where it doesn't exist (Andersen, 2024; Coston & Kimmel, 2012). Yet, our analysis of incels.is indicates that some less privileged men construct inequality where it does not exist.

Our analysis demonstrates a process that we call zeroing out, which entails less advantaged members of a privileged group appropriating the experiences of marginalized groups and demanding reparations for the entitlements they believe they are owed but denied. Incels.is users likened inceldom to a disability and a marginalized sexual identity by claiming that their physical appearance, neurodivergence, and attraction to women who are not attracted to them deny them their masculine right to women's sexual subservience. Consistent with Chouliaraki's (2024) observations of the actions of the privileged in a culture of victimhood, incels equated their individual experience of loneliness with the systemic oppression of marginalized groups. They then used their grievances as grounds for an uprising to obtain the masculine privileges they believe they are owed.

Our findings both align with, and depart from, two tenets of the zero-sum worldview. First, subscribing to zero-sum beliefs is associated with decreased willingness to help others, especially those from less advantaged groups (Chernyak-Hai & Davidai, 2022). Consistent with this tendency, we saw incels appropriating the status of marginalized groups while also disparaging those groups and/or their efforts at collective action (e.g., #MeToo, Black Lives Matter). A review of the literature on boundary-crossing in social movements indicates that alliances can be formed between groups when their identities or self-representations overlap (Wang et al., 2018). For example, if incels truly view themselves as a group that is marginalized by their sexual identity then they could seek to ally themselves with LGBTQ+ rights groups (although, such bridging requires LGBTQ+ groups to welcome this alliance). Instead, our analysis indicates that incels deride LGBTQ+ groups. In fact, past research demonstrates that incels tend to align themselves with the ideology of other aggrieved privileged groups, such as white supremacists (Gheorghe, 2024; Glace et al., 2021; Hoffman et al., 2020; Pruden et al., 2022). In general, our findings are consistent with these larger patterns in the zero-sum and social movement literature. What is unique about our findings is they demonstrate that incels do not simply express lack of willingness to help marginalized groups. Incels first appropriate the identities of marginalized groups and then distance themselves from these groups in a way that frames themselves as authentically disadvantaged.

The second way that our findings relate to tenets of the zero-sum worldview is that individuals who subscribe to zero-sum thinking tend to see privilege in asymmetrical ways such that the gains of others come at their group's expense, but their own group's gains come at the expense of no one (Roberts & Davidai, 2022; Wilkins et al., 2015). In our analysis, incels demanded reparations in a manner that has clear and serious costs to others (e.g., advocating for women's sexual servitude, rape, murder, etc.). Incels relished

the subordination of women as a cost of their own personal gains. This is similar to, and may help us understand, findings from past research that demonstrates members of privileged groups calling for retribution against members of less advantaged groups for alleged transgressions that societal/cultural gains have purportedly enabled. For example, studies of a range of Manosphere groups (e.g., incels, men's rights activists, pickup artists) highlight men's calls for the subordination and victimization of women whom they allege have been emboldened by the #MeToo movement to make false allegations of sexual assault against men (Dickel & Evolvi, 2023; Gotell & Dutton, 2016; Kettrey et al., 2024). Such excitement over anticipated costs experienced by another group may be especially pronounced in the Manosphere, as these groups are markedly defined by aggrievement.

In fact, we believe our findings illustrate the intersection of zero-sum thinking and aggrieved entitlement. According to Kimmel (2017), aggrieved entitlement entails feelings of anger surrounding the belief that one has been denied privileges they are owed. In this case, incels expressed anger in the form of grievances directed toward more privileged men and threats of violence against women in reaction to the denial of their perceived masculine entitlement to women's romantic and sexual services.

Pairing aggrieved entitlement with zero-sum thinking, incels.is users zeroed out. Instead of constructing privilege where it does not exist, as demonstrated by previous research (Coston & Kimmel, 2012), incels.is users constructed inequality where it does not exist. Incels expressed aggrievement over the deprivation of sexual services they believe women owe them. Integrating this sense of entitlement with zero-sum thinking, they perceived this denial of sex to be the result of women's increased agency (between-group comparison) and the belief that higher-status men were ostensibly keeping women's sexual services for themselves (within-group comparison). As a result of deeming themselves deprived regarding both their between-group and within-group statuses, they viewed themselves as a marginalized group. They drew their masculine value down to zero, generating a large inequality gap between themselves and more privileged men as justification for their demands for reparations in the form of a masculine dividend.

Limitations and Future Research Directions

Findings from our analysis must be interpreted within the confines of some important limitations. First, our netnography was limited to one online forum (i.e., incels.is). Although we intentionally selected this forum based on the fact that it is considered to be the most popular among incels, its content is more extreme than some less popular forums such as r/IncelExit, which was created for men contemplating leaving the incel community (Davis & Kettrey, 2024). Second, as previously discussed, our positionality as women prohibited us from recruiting incels into a planned survey, as incels.is explicitly bans women from posting to the forum. Thus, our analysis is based on messages that incels shared with each other in a public space. This leads us to a third, related limitation. Based on our method of data collection, our findings should be considered observational, as we did not interact directly with incels themselves and we did not have the opportunity to ask for clarification regarding our interpretation of the logic circulated in this forum. Although we believe immersing ourselves in the incels.is environment allowed us to observe the way that incel identity is collectively formed, it prevented us from gaining insight into individual meanings that incels form but do not share with the larger community.

Finally, it is important for future research to assess whether our findings apply to other groups that center on masculine grievances. For example, future studies may be conducted in other realms of the Manosphere such as those occupied by men's rights activists, men going their own way (MGTOW), and pick up artists. Such studies may elucidate the messages conveyed by men who do not necessarily frame themselves as occupying the very bottom of the masculine hierarchy, but express aggrievement about the privileges that their relative position on the masculine hierarchy denies them. It is important that such research includes interviews with members of the population of interest. This should be feasible with non-incel communities in the Manosphere, as their membership requirements do not tend to be exclusive to men.

Practice Implications

Incels express aggrieved entitlement over their perceived failures at sexual and romantic relationships with women. In recent years, popular media and the Manosphere have both promulgated a narrative of a "male loneliness epidemic" in which men have more difficulty finding emotional connection than women (see Orchard, 2025). Although data from the Pew Research Center indicate that men and women report loneliness in similar proportions, data also indicate that men mostly rely on romantic relationships for emotional support whereas women rely on a wide range of relationships for support (Goddard & Parker, 2025). Thus, men appear to have fewer sources of emotional connection than women, but they do not necessarily report more loneliness. Regardless of the empirical veracity of the male loneliness epidemic, the promulgation of this narrative has serious implications for the ways that men view their relative position in social hierarchies.

According to a recent scoping review of research on masculinity and loneliness, one way that men cope with feelings of loneliness is by rejecting diversity and vulnerability, such as by normalizing sexism, racism, homophobia, and violence (Nordin et al., 2024). In fact, research has associated rejection and exclusion with a tendency toward political extremism (Pfundmair et al., 2024; Renström et al., 2020). This is evident in our findings, as incels promulgated acts of violence as retribution for their social aggrievements. As the presumed plight of the straight White male proliferates in the Manosphere (Hanson et al., 2023), it will be important to consider the ways that some men compare themselves to more privileged in-group members and appropriate the oppression of less powerful groups. In other words, zeroing out, as we have called it, could push some men to extremism and violence.

This is especially important considering that Manosphere rhetoric plays to the vulnerabilities of young men who feel displaced by an unstable and shifting gender power structure (Banet-Weiser et al., 2023; Botto & Gottzén, 2024) and that journalists and activists have noted the seepage of Manosphere rhetoric into popular media and politics, including in the rhetoric circulated by adolescent boys (Bates, 2020; Reeve, 2024). Thus, it is important for those working with adolescent boys and young men to be vigilant to the romantic and social rejection some may feel while also avoiding promulgating a "male loneliness epidemic" narrative in a manner that justifies hate and violence toward women and marginalized groups.

Conclusion

Logic circulated in the Manosphere asserting that women's advancements come at the expense of men is a product of a zero-sum worldview, which posits that one group's success comes at a cost to others (Davidai & Tepper, 2023). In fact, zero-sum beliefs are common among members of privileged groups who believe their group is under threat (Roberts & Davidai, 2022), such as men in the Manosphere who feel they are losing status to women. Most scholarly work on zero-sum ideology focuses on power between groups, rather than within groups. Such focus overlooks grievances held by less-advantaged members of privileged groups, such as men who do not receive full benefits of masculine privilege. In our study, we examined the ways incels construct inequality in a presumed zero-sum game where the gains of women (between-group comparison) and higher-status men (within-group comparison) are believed to come at a personal cost. By viewing themselves as deprived regarding both their between-group and within-group statuses, incels cast themselves as a marginalized group.

Through a process that we call zeroing out, we found that incels appropriated the identity of marginalized groups that have demonstrated success in bringing visibility to their societal disadvantage. Incels strategically adopt systemic inequality in a way that appropriates the experiences of the underprivileged for the purpose of securing the entitlements they feel they are owed, but denied, as a lower-status member of a privileged group. By studying members of a privileged group who view themselves as deprived, we hope findings from our analysis shed some light on the in-group dynamics of privilege among those who adhere to a zero-sum worldview. More specifically, we believe our findings highlight the ways that underprivileged members of privileged groups may devalue themselves as a means of generating noise in what Chouliaraki (2024) calls a culture of victimhood. Such noise of individual pain not only silences those who are systemically oppressed but, through the lens of aggrieved entitlement, also amplifies the voice of privilege. As long as the voices of the privileged are amplified, and pantomime voices of the oppressed, inequality will continue to be legitimized.

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Data Availability Data for this study were collected through immersive netnographic methods and are not available in raw form.

Declarations

Competing Interests The authors declare no competing interests.

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